ANALYST INSTITUTE

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2025-2026 Community-Informed Research Agenda

Executive Summary

In the wake of 2024, the Left needs more than marginal improvements to existing tactics—it needs bold rethinking of strategy, fearless innovation, and an ambitious research agenda to meet the scale of the challenges we face. **Analyst Institute's 2025–2026 Community-Informed Research Agenda highlights the key research needed to get us back on track for victory, now and for the long term.**

This agenda focuses on four major areas:

1. **Conventional Tactics:** Revisiting core tactics like canvassing, ad testing, and mail to ensure they deliver meaningful impact grounded in today's realities, not yesterday's assumptions.
2. **Understudied and Emergent Tactics:** Accelerating testing of newer, less-measured approaches, including organic digital engagement, combined persuasion and mobilization programs, and partisan voter registration to meet and move critical audiences where they are.
3. **Foundational Research on Environmental Shifts:** Understanding how civic disengagement, media fragmentation, and institutional distrust are reshaping the political terrain, and how strategy must adapt in response.
4. **Bridging Research and Practice:** Research is only useful if it's acted on. We call for deeper investment in infrastructure that helps turn findings into field-ready practices and a shift toward investment frameworks that account for strategic importance, long-term value, and the votes that cost more but matter most. Donors and advisors must be part of this shift by rewarding candor, learning, and bold experimentation, not just tidy wins.

The 2025–2026 agenda reflects Analyst Institute's commitment to leading and aligning shared research efforts—grounded in rigor, transparency, lived experience, and real-world impact. **We invite partners to join us in charting the next chapter, together.**

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A Post-2024 Strategic Reset

The results of the 2024 election have many across the Left feeling unsure where to turn next. And not just because of the top-of-the-ticket defeat. The outcome exposed something deeper: a jarring reminder that **we lack a unified strategy to counter the threats and broader societal shifts that now shape our politics.**

And unfortunately, the road ahead is only getting tougher. We're confronting a mix of structural, cultural, and political challenges—from a punishing Senate map and population shifts affecting the Electoral College, to growing distrust and civic isolation, to a weakened Democratic brand, especially among young voters and voters of color—all amid a global tide of authoritarianism and escalating attacks on democratic norms.

In moments like this, it's easy to feel like all is lost and the entire playbook needs to be thrown out. **But while it's urgent to chart new approaches to meet the scale of today's challenges, we shouldn't abandon what we know works.**

Decades of research, at Analyst Institute and across the movement, have built a foundational understanding of tactics that reliably drive voter engagement and support. And fresh evidence from 2024 underscores this point. For example, the Harris campaign overperformed in battleground states where its organizing and communications programs were most robust, and down-ballot Democrats exceeded expectations in tough races.

The problem facing the field isn't tactical failure, it's strategic mismatch. Our ecosystem has for too long relied on narrowly-defined research questions focused on short-term tactics to solve deeply rooted structural problems.

Expanding What We Measure and Value

Over the past two decades, randomized controlled trials (RCTs) have defined much of our shared evidence base. And for good reason: RCTs are powerful when applied to tactics that are individually targeted, easily isolated, and measurable through reliable outcome data like voter turnout.

But that approach has, by design, focused on tactical low-hanging fruit. While it's yielded valuable insights, it has also left critical gaps in what we understand and value, especially around core drivers of political influence like identity, narrative, social networks, and culture, which aren't easily measured through traditional experiments.

Analyst Institute is changing that. We're helping our movement think bigger, innovate faster, and embrace holistic research approaches that can chart new paths forward

This includes:

- **Rigorous, transparent, and context-aware approaches** that complement, rather than replace, the RCT foundation we've built. We're ramping up our yearslong emphasis on incorporating shifting political atmospherics and bold experimentation beyond routine program evaluations.
- **Multi-mode research strategies** that triangulate evidence across experimental, observational, and qualitative methods when clean RCTs aren't feasible. We've honed our approach in recent years to better reflect the complexity of today's landscape and ensure attention to both internal validity and real-world impact.
- **Evidence frameworks that strengthen diverse theories of change**, from campaign tactics to deep organizing, infrastructure, and narrative work.

Through it all, our role is to stay grounded in what the evidence tells us about how those strategies can be most effective and to **help all our partners do their good work, *better.***

Analyst Institute: The Force Magnifier for Research-Driven Impact

For nearly 20 years, Analyst Institute has served as the **central hub for research and shared learning** across the Democratic, progressive, and civic engagement communities, supporting smarter programs and investment strategies among a network of 15,000+ partners, operating in all 50 states and at every level of the ballot.

We're best known for producing original research—dozens of best-in-class studies each year that help campaigns and organizations test new ideas, challenge conventional wisdom, refine tactics, and increase impact. But this moment demands more than just more individual studies; it needs coordinated, strategic insight. We're deepening our commitment to meeting that need.

Building on our long history as a trusted and independent expert, Analyst Institute is expanding our role as **an unbeholden arbiter of evidence across the field.**

This evolution is powered by the **research culture** Analyst Institute has built, including our expansive network of alumni embedded in leading organizations.

It also reflects our role as a **community utility**; while many organizations conduct research solely for internal use, Analyst Institute is the only research entity focused on transparency and shared learning. **We share everything—including what doesn't work—because our movement can't afford to ignore hard truths.** And we make 20+ years of research available to everyone working in the organizations we serve, along with tools and training to put it into practice, at no cost.

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2025–2026 Community-Informed Research Agenda

The Community-Informed Research Agenda is one of our core tools for shaping the field's shared research priorities. It reflects Analyst Institute's expert synthesis of existing evidence and the urgent strategic questions we've heard from hundreds of partners, funders, and organizers across the movement. This is not just a roadmap for our work; it's a call to align and accelerate collective research efforts across the ecosystem.

The challenge now is to push beyond what's historically been measurable and past a culture that too often uses research to evaluate or punish rather than to learn, adapt, and innovate.

This agenda is rigorous, quantitative, and grounded in the lived experiences of our partners and the communities they serve. It's also our invitation to rethink how we measure impact, challenge outdated assumptions, and build the research frameworks this moment demands.

Let's chart what comes next—together.

1. Conventional Tactics

Over the past two decades, Analyst Institute has rigorously tested many widely used campaign tactics, establishing scalable best practices like social pressure mail and identifying others with small, null, or inconsistent effects. But the **assumptions behind a few core recommendations haven't been systematically retested in years**. As context shifts, it's critical to revisit and replicate past findings for an updated understanding of how well these tactics work today (or don't), under which conditions, and how they compare in overall effect and efficiency against more emergent tactics.

Some of the most widely used tactics still rest on surprisingly thin or outdated evidence. To move beyond legacy assumptions, stakeholders need a stronger, more current foundation to guide smart, scalable investment.

Key Research Priorities

Best practice canvassing for persuasion and mobilization

Door-to-door canvassing for persuasion and GOTV is an evergreen campaign tactic, but there is significant uncertainty about the continued effectiveness of common canvass program designs. Future research should not only clarify the effect of this tactic across contexts and audiences, but also demonstrate any lift provided by implementable best practices.

What we know:

- Analyst Institute's Meta-Analysis 4.0 finds that, on average, door-to-door canvassing has not had a consistent, measurable impact on voter turnout. Likewise, academic meta-analysis has not found a consistent average effect of standard canvassing on vote choice.
- Individual tests of canvass programs have had mixed results, in part due to variations in execution, unique contexts, and adherence to best practices. As a result, these tests show us on average, how effective canvassing *has been*, but not how effective it *could be*.
- Though not definitive, outlier programs with strong, positive effects tend to leverage warm relationships, sustain activity over time, use best-practice scripts, and deploy strategies to maximize contact rates. However, these strategies can be costly, time-consuming, and difficult to scale.
- Though canvassing is much less cost-efficient than other methods, in theory it allows organizations to reach disengaged audiences unreachable by other modes as well as to have deeper, more dynamic real-life interactions with members of their communities.
- Early-cycle canvassing can be persuasive, but effects decay quickly without sustained engagement. Deep canvassing and candidate canvassing have shown promise as well.

- Canvassing has been shown to have a positive effect on the canvassers, reducing affective polarization through interactions with voters.

What we need to learn and build:

- We need baseline RCTs of mobilization, persuasion, and multi-goal canvass programs that use best-practice scripts and robust quality control measures. This will better situate canvass programs in the context of other voter contact modes.
- Beyond baseline effects, we must also explore variations in program design and execution that might further enhance effectiveness, stabilize costs, and support organizations in adhering to best practices. These studies will demonstrate the potential effectiveness of canvassing when optimized.
- Canvassing may be comparatively inefficient as a late-cycle persuasion or GOTV tool, but it's worth testing its long-term value when leveraged earlier in the cycle, particularly through sustained, high-quality interactions in hard-to-reach communities.

Correspondence between survey and field-based ad RCTs

Survey-based ad testing has become a standard practice across the ecosystem due to its speed and accessibility. Implicit in its use is the assumption that survey-based effects correlate directly (albeit at a smaller magnitude) to real-world persuasion effects. Existing research has found real, but muted and statistically-noisy, correlations when validated by precinct-level randomized RCTs using electoral returns.

Given the billions spent on advertising each cycle, it's well worth investing in more field RCTs to better understand the validity of survey ad tests and the magnitude of real-world effects in different contexts. How do differences in content delivery support, or complicate, our ability to measure true effects? Additionally, it's critical to highlight best practice use of ad testing, on its own and in light of other data inputs such as polling and modeling as part of programmatic decision-making.

What we know:

- Survey-based ad tests are positively correlated with effects found in field RCTs, but the relationship is noisy due to overlapping sources of measurement error. For example, a 2020 study done by Open Labs found a positive correlation between in-survey and in-field ad effects of 0.43.
- Survey-based ad effects are consistently larger in magnitude than those seen in the real world. Respondents in survey ad-tests are incentivized to watch the ad, and measurement takes place immediately after viewing— conditions that differ significantly from real-world ad exposure.

- Meta-analyses of ad effects are increasingly used to identify topics, messengers, tone, and other characteristics associated with highly persuasive content as well as to benchmark ad performance across organizations.

What we need to learn and build:

- The "gold-standard" comparison of survey-based testing vs. randomized TV ads has not been sufficiently extended to digital platforms. As digital consumption rises, it is worth exploring whether certain digital platforms enable more precise measurement of real-world effects than standard zip or market-randomized tests or TV-addressable tests with survey follow-up.
- Resources that make plain the correlation between survey ad tests and real-world effects should be a public good. Running real-world field tests is expensive and risky for individual organizations, especially when testing ads that perform poorly in surveys. A coordinated, ecosystem-wide testing effort would both reduce risk and generate broader, more reliable insights that don't overindex on any single organization's findings and context.
- We also need a better, and updated, understanding of critical design and measurement differences across ad testing platforms/vendors. Most organizations use a single platform/vendor to test ads, but methodological differences can result in divergent findings. An updated comparative analysis would help consumers of test results better interpret differences in findings across firms and contexts.
- Improving our understanding of how survey results translate to field performance would help the movement use survey-based meta-analyses more responsibly as well. Right now, these meta-analyses often assume a direct but smaller-magnitude relationship, which may not hold across message types, audiences, or delivery environments.

Mail volume, timing, and content

Classic studies by Analyst Institute and others established the effectiveness of social pressure mail and related techniques. Future testing should explore new frontiers of social accountability and behavioral incentives to support both mobilization and persuasion efforts across diverse audiences. Similarly, assumptions about cadence, volume, and multi-mode layering deserve fresh review in light of a shifting communications landscape in which voter attention and message saturation are key constraints.

What we know:

- Mail, especially social pressure mail, remains a highly reliable mode of contact for GOTV.

- It's highly cost effective, scalable, and allows for sophisticated targeting and personalization by audience. It's impactful on its own and when layered with other modes.
- However, analyses from Mintt suggest under-utilization of mail in recent election cycles relative to Republicans.
- Novel formats, such as ballot guides and local newsletters, have shown promising early results.
- Mail can be particularly effective in persuading in down-ballot races where candidates are less well-known.

What we need to learn and build:

- We need RCTs to evaluate how effective persuasion mail remains with under-engaged audiences, especially young voters and voters of color, in a changed communications landscape.
- We should retest the impact of layering mail with other outreach modes, such as digital, TV, and canvassing, to assess how integrated approaches improve reach and effectiveness given changes in media consumption and engagement.
- It's important to compare the performance of condensed mail programs to longer, slow-burn schedules.
- We also need to better consider the optimal number of persuasion mail pieces, balancing both cumulative program impact and marginal returns that may plateau or diminish.

Additional Research Priorities

Sustained engagement and optimal outreach timing

Too often, voter contact is compressed into the final weeks of a campaign, but the most effective programs may be those that build earlier and last longer. We need clearer evidence on how spring and summer outreach efforts can strengthen fall performance efficiently and cost-effectively, and whether sustained engagement throughout the year drives greater gains in turnout and vote share than last-minute contact alone.

Future research should examine the additive value of early and sustained outreach as part of member/supporter/list-building programs. We also need to reassess optimal program timelines in light of expanding vote-by-mail and early voting windows, particularly for down-ballot contests where early impressions may carry greater weight.

Equally important is understanding how off-cycle engagement strategies can strengthen

campaign infrastructure by recruiting, training, and retaining organizers or activists who drive stronger on-cycle performance.

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2. Understudied or Emergent Tactics

Newer and less thoroughly studied tactics present **major opportunities for innovation and efficiency gains,** especially as communications behaviors and technologies evolve.

Many of these approaches center on digital platforms such as social media, where audiences are spending increasing amounts of time but where best practices remain underdeveloped because measurement is challenging and algorithms keep shifting. We need more research in these areas to run better, more modern campaigns that meet critical audiences where they are.

Key Research Priorities

Organic digital content and audience exploration

As more Americans live their lives online, campaigns and organizations are investing more heavily in digital paid media than ever before, with a notable focus in recent years on organic content. Republican dominance of podcasts and the digital influencer ecosystem in 2024 has sparked concerns that the Left is behind and underinvested in organic content.

What we know:

- Organic content is difficult to study because digital platforms limit visibility into audiences.
- The American media landscape is increasingly fragmented, with attention spread across traditional cable and broadcast TV, streaming services, and social media.
- Gen Z and Millennials, in particular, are the heaviest users of newer social media platforms like TikTok and the most likely to get news regularly from those platforms.
- With trust in politics, candidates, and traditional media at an all-time low, content delivered through known and reliable sources, including personal connections and influencers of any scale, seems to be both powerful and durable.

What we need to learn and build:

- We need RCTs and descriptive analyses to better understand how effectively organic content reaches and influences target audiences, while developing more robust strategies for audience identification, outcome tracking, and evaluation. These tests can also provide insight into the tradeoffs between efficiency and reach of 1:1 list-based and geographic targeting.
- We need stronger methods for assessing the correspondence between digital survey responses and real-world behavioral effects, particularly given the wide gap between testing environments and actual content consumption on social media.

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- More research is needed on the relationship between persuasiveness and virality. Content that spreads isn't always what persuades; understanding that tradeoff is critical for effective digital strategy.
- The role of warm and parasocial relationships—where audiences feel affinity or trust with influencers or content creators—should be tested for its impact on message uptake, trust, and mobilization, particularly among disengaged or skeptical voters.
- More descriptive and qualitative research would add enormous value in this space as well. For example, a critical resource we lack is any sort of widely-shared, regularly conducted representative survey that summarizes where target audiences are spending their time, what news is breaking through on which platforms, and how these change over time. Similarly, centralizing information on changes to platforms' algorithmic and content delivery processes would help ensure impactful targeting and communications.
- Practitioners also often lack the information necessary to make smart platform and vendor decisions in this space. A helpful resource would provide guidelines on how to choose digital firms and what questions to ask to understand the realistic capabilities of various tools.

Combining mobilization and persuasion

We need to do much more to understand the best messages and tactics that combine persuasion and mobilization. Infrequent voters, particularly less-engaged young, Black, Latino, and AAPI voters, saw the largest swings toward Republicans in 2024. Despite this deterioration in support, majorities of most of these groups continue to vote for Democrats, meaning that many of these voters are both mobilization *and* persuasion targets.

What we know:

- Persuasion content alone has not been found to increase voter turnout, but recent research suggests that integrating elements of persuasion messaging into mobilization mail can yield positive turnout effects.
- Because traditional mobilization targets are trending away from Democrats, integrating persuasive messaging into outreach to these voters may be necessary to maintain and regain support.

What we need to learn and build:

- We need to test the most effective ways to communicate persuasion and mobilization content to voters with RCTs that measure both voter turnout and vote choice within a single program.

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- RCTs across organizations engaging with voters can also help us assess the value of layered tactics and messages, with some organizations delivering persuasion and others mobilization messages.
- More holistic measurements of combined persuasion and turnout effects would support programmatic groups and support funders to resource these programs accordingly.

Additional Research Priorities

Partisan voter registration

Voter registration remains one of the most consistently effective and cost-efficient tools in the field—and one of the few with clear potential for multi-cycle impact. When done at scale, especially in historically marginalized communities, registration programs help combat political invisibility and support building a representative electorate and democracy.

But erosions in Democratic support among young voters and voters of color in 2024 raise real questions about the strategic limits of nonpartisan registration alone. In a high-stakes, polarized environment, partisan registration efforts may play a distinct and increasingly important role, where possible via available funding.

Future research should focus on identifying best practices in messaging and design for partisan voter registration tactics, especially in site-based programs in base- and mixed-partisanship localities, varying electoral contexts, and relational or online environments. Understanding how these programs perform and how they differ from nonpartisan models is essential to building long-term support and Democratic affiliation.

Relational organizing beyond voter turnout

Relational organizing continues to show promise for boosting voter turnout, particularly in communities that are underengaged or harder to reach through other tactics. Past tests have demonstrated its impact, and recent innovations—including the use of paid relational organizers, new digital tools, and strategies to expand reach beyond close-knit networks—have improved its scalability, though challenges remain.

Future research should examine how to further expand scale and reach, including through hybrid strategies that combine online and offline relational efforts, and tactics designed to counteract homophily within networks. We must also explore relational organizing's potential beyond mobilization. We need more evidence on its effectiveness for voter registration, persuasion, and volunteer activation, especially in contexts where trust and authenticity are critical.

Finally, we should continue exploring how to build and sustain relational continuity across election cycles—especially at scale. While some volunteer-driven organizations have already

developed ways to track and maintain these relationships over time, we know far less about how this could work in paid or large-scale programs. Unlocking those dynamics could lead to major gains in both efficiency and long-term impact.

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3. Foundational Research on Environmental Shifts

In addition to evaluating individual tactics, we need deeper, sustained research to understand the broader dynamics shaping our work. These aren't questions that can be answered with simple, single-cycle RCTs. Instead, they require longer-term research investment and new or creative methodologies.

This research helps establish a baseline understanding of how we might **influence the atmospheric and contextual forces that underlie campaigns and organizing**: shifting voter attitudes, media ecosystems, trust in institutions, and civic infrastructure, among others. It's foundational work that informs not just program design, but also strategic planning and investment across the field.

Key Research Priorities

Messengers that resonate

The aftermath of the 2024 election laid bare a critical gap in the media ecosystem: Democrats do not have the same presence as Republicans in online cultural spaces. These relationships are built over years and require sustained engagement from candidates and organizations, and messaging that creates connection between influencers/brands and voters on cultural and day-to-day levels.

What we know:

- Voters least likely to consume traditional media are the voters we most need to connect with moving forward. Many of these voters trust social media at least as much as national news media and use social media as a significant source of news and information.
- Ad testing confirms that messengers matter for persuasion.
- Survey-based content testing results and reach data–such as those circulated in the Doppler newsletter–show that organic content and social media clips can be highly persuasive and have the potential to reach people who do not seek out news or political content.

What we need to learn and build:

- Digital influencers can offer valuable insight into their audiences and how to engage them. We should explore how to best develop long-term relationships with digital personalities and influencers to develop best practices for communicating with voters on platforms built for entertainment, not politics.
- Exploring the qualities of messengers and messages that are considered trustworthy can

help us design programs that convey credibility and activate voters. Future tests could examine how messenger effectiveness varies by platform or mode given the unique composition of audiences across spaces, and whether known, elite, or celebrity messengers are better suited to different types of messages.

- Many organizations ran large (paid or volunteer) influencer programs in the 2024 cycle. The ecosystem would benefit from a quantitative and qualitative review of these programs: their structure, associated costs, measurement strategies, and observational ROI metrics.
- Beyond macroinfluencers and celebrities, how can organizations better identify and leverage microinfluencers and trusted community messengers to deliver content with potency?
- In parallel with that of personal or organizational accounts, what is the role and value of unbranded content as part of public conversation?

Understanding disengaged voters

We have increasingly seen that less politically engaged voters are both drifting toward Republicans *and* are less likely to take surveys than more engaged voters. So, in addition to a political challenge, this engagement divide presents a difficult *measurement challenge* for Democrats. We will not be able to figure out what content and approaches are effective with these voters if we cannot accurately understand who they are, their interests and motivations, and where/how they engage with both politics and culture.

What we know:

- Engaged voters have long been known to be over-represented in surveys.
- Infrequent voters have distinct political views and have become significantly more Republican over the past five years.
- Political polling was more accurate in 2024 than in past presidential elections but still underestimated Donald Trump's support. This measurement error may be due in part to difficulties precisely estimating possibly disengaged voters' movement to Trump.

What we need to learn and build:

- We need to evaluate how well disengaged voters were captured in 2024 pre-election polling.
- Additionally, we must develop improved polling methodologies and population benchmarks to better capture disengaged and low-information voters, ensuring more representative samples for future testing and message development.

- Beyond survey accuracy, we should Invest in new and creative research methods to understand the identities, values, and lived experiences of disengaged voters as a critical input to more effective engagement.

Power-building and the strengthening of democratic practice

Organizing and power-building are not just tactics used within a campaign cycle, they are foundational strategies that shape the democratic landscape. In the face of rising authoritarianism, these efforts help cultivate civic capacity, anchor long-term infrastructure, and influence the conditions under which electoral and policy wins become possible.

While the field has made important strides in developing measurement frameworks for power-building, these outcomes remain far harder to capture than traditional electoral metrics. We need clearer definitions of success, stronger methods for evaluating impact, and greater support for applying these tools across program design and as part of cultivating pro-democracy ecosystems.

What we know:

- In 2022, Analyst Institute worked with partner organizations to create the Pathways to Power Metrics Toolkit, which outlines a conceptual measurement framework to inform long-term power-building. Similarly, DPI's Power Metrics: Measuring What Matters report provides recommendations based on their multi-year organizing lab.
- Research has also begun to assess the strength of pro-democracy ecosystems shaping the context in which power-building efforts take place.

What we need to learn and build:

- We need to explore how efforts to build power and strengthen democratic practice support in-cycle and multi-cycle engagement, activation, and support, and further define impact and ROI frameworks that properly situate this work.
- At its core, this must also include deeper research on the root causes of political disaffection and cynicism, as well as concrete strategies for building personal political efficacy.
- We need RCTs that map specific tactics and strategies to their impact on key power metrics, such as media coverage, membership, elite opinion, and leadership development.

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- Finally, descriptive studies of organizations' power-building approaches when faced with increasing anti-democratic pressure can model paths forward for similar entities. For example, how can organizations build and maintain organizing capacity under administrative and legal scrutiny? Under what circumstances do service-based community organizations translate their success into political organizing capacity?

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4. Bridging Research and Practice

As the progressive ecosystem becomes more distributed and complex, the role of research must expand beyond one-off experimentation. **We need stronger infrastructure to centralize, synthesize, and apply what we learn**—supporting both program-level optimization and cross-program investment, in alignment with the diverse theories of change that guide our field.

This includes building the **systems, standards, and culture** that allow research to inform real-time decision-making and adapting those systems to meet the challenges and opportunities presented by evolving technologies such as generative artificial intelligence.

Key Research Priorities

Last-mile problem

Analyst Institute was founded to coordinate and refine the quantitative research efforts of allied organizations, distilling best practices to maximize impact. While we have developed clear recommendations, many organizations do not fully implement them for various reasons. To maximize impact, we must explore how to bridge the gap between research and practice and ensure that insights translate into action.

What we know:

- We have strong, evidence-based guidance on scripts, tools, and methods to enhance the effectiveness of voter contact programs. These proven approaches provide organizations with actionable strategies to maximize their impact and reach.
- We also recognize that many organizations do not consistently implement best-practice recommendations.

What we need to learn and build:

- We need to better understand why, and under what circumstances, organizations do not implement best-practice recommendations. Possible explanations include concerns about the relevance or generalizability of past research, disagreement or disbelief of evidence, and lack of awareness.
- Qualitative research into how decisions are made and best practices are adopted across organizations would help us better understand the gap between common and best practices, identify the role of key decision-makers, barriers to adoption, and points of intervention. How can we align incentives on programs so organizers are motivated to deliver quality? What staff training, management support, and/or general professionalization is needed to further engrain reliance on best practices across the campaign industry?

- Future RCTs should more directly compare best practice approaches to commonly used alternatives, to illustrate the gains provided by best practices and further their adoption across the ecosystem.

Continued meta-analysis and learning from outliers

Analyst Institute's Meta-Analysis 4.0 remains the largest synthesis of randomized experiments in the social sciences—offering unprecedented insight into how voter turnout programs perform across modes, audiences, and contexts. More recently, we've extended this work to examine downstream effects of GOTV programs across time.

What we know:

- Meta-analysis is uniquely powerful: it identifies patterns that no single study can surface on its own, places new results in context, and flags outlier programs—especially high performers—for further investigation and real-world replication.
- It is one of the field's most important tools for moving from scattered insights to coordinated, data-backed strategy, and a key tool for countering file-drawer issues in the sharing of null or negative results.
- Analyst Institute's meta-analytic results are used by hundreds of partners community-wide to make programmatic and funding decisions, making it one of the most valuable tools at our disposal.

What we need to learn and build:

- We need to incorporate the growing body of recent community-led research into future GOTV meta-analyses to ensure that the results reflect the full range of research, not just studies conducted by Analyst Institute.
- We should develop individual-level meta-analyses focused on voter registration and persuasion programs to estimate group-level differences in treatment effectiveness.
- Meta-analyses should be expanded beyond traditional variables like electoral context, mode of contact, and audience demographics to include place-based and socioeconomic/class/income analyses.
- We must also delve deeper into key modes of contact in need of extra investigation, such as digital and canvass, via mode-specific meta-analyses. High-performing programs can point to hypotheses worth testing through deeper analysis.

Impact investment frameworks

Testing limitations have long shaped what we value and fund, but the challenges we face now require a more holistic view. To build lasting impact, we need both new ways of measuring program effect and more expansive frameworks for understanding program value across short- and long-term horizons, and within critical communities and geographies.

What we know:

- Impact (as measured through net votes/net Democratic votes generated) and cost efficiency (as measured by cost-per-vote) have become widely used tools for evaluating programs and guiding cross-program investment decisions. They can be instructive in the situations where they are calculated thoughtfully, appropriately, and with reliable data.
- However, their real-world and conceptual limitations are notable. Many impactful programs are not conducive to using RCTs, and costs vary widely across geographies and program structures, making apples-to-apples comparisons unreliable and sometimes misleading.
- Naive or decontextualized use of cost-per-vote often overweights easily measurable programs and undervalues complex, layered, or long-term efforts. But the absence of cost-efficiency metrics shouldn't imply lower value—nor should it exempt programs from demonstrating impact. We also need to move beyond chasing the cheapest votes and reframe cost efficiency as a tool for comparing strategic value, recognizing that some votes are worth more to win and may justify higher costs.

What we need to learn and build:

- To support smarter program and funding decisions, we need more flexible, robust frameworks that assess both the full value of individual programs and the strategic value of the contests or goals they serve, recognizing that investment levels and tolerance for cost efficiency should be calibrated based on the importance of the race or objective. This might include:
    - Investment needed to create a lifetime voter or supporter, to capture longer-term engagement and retention.
    - Cost-per-vote-cast across the full ballot, especially for down-ballot races.
    - Return on investment for must-win races, incorporating program effects on both margin and scale.

- Conceptual models of multi-cycle goals and impact, to guide investment in infrastructure or programs with delayed returns.
- Rigorous, yet context-aware, heuristics for comparing hard-to-test programs, using available evidence, contextual cues, and strategic value—not just testability.
- Mapping the cumulative effects of many programs on voters in an election to understand the broader impact of community-wide efforts to mobilize and persuade. Doing so requires a more robust and representative collection of program impact assessments, as well as cost data. This need is especially pressing for novel programs and those for which there has been little study to date.

Incentivizing innovation and risk-tolerant research sharing

Too often, the structure of funding and research incentives rewards only what works right now—discouraging organizations from taking risks, trying bold new ideas, or openly sharing what doesn't work. If we want to build smarter, more future-ready programs, we need to create space and support for research on tactics that fail, as this shows us where to improve or invest differently next time.

What we know:

- Results are frequently siloed within organizations, and in-cycle sharing can be limited by campaign finance constraints.
- Despite significant efforts to date, some research, particularly of null or negative results, is kept private within organizations and not shared for the purpose of collective learning.
- And for first-of-its-kind research on emergent tactics, there is often too much lag time between when an idea is first tried, tested, and results are shared with the wider community to spur scaled innovation.
- Donors increasingly rely on data and metrics to make funding decisions, which has had the consequence of politicizing information-sharing. Organizations may be reluctant to share any data points that do not show the robust success of their programs for fear of funder backlash.

What we need to learn and build:

- We need to explore ways to incentivize information sharing across the ecosystem, particularly at the methodological and tactical cutting-edge.
- We should try different formats for webinars, conferences, walls-down meetings, and other, less formal exchanges of information that would allow for candid conversations about research.

- How donor behavior, advisor incentives, and funder norms can better support innovation—including reframing "failure" as essential learning, and rewarding bold attempts, not just polished wins.
- Expanding Analyst Institute's meta-analysis to include the community's full array of research can help mitigate the file-drawer problem by incorporating null results in a more discrete or anonymous fashion.

Generative A.I.

The rise of generative artificial intelligence (gen-A.I.) presents both opportunities and challenges for the progressive ecosystem. Analyst Institute can serve as a clearinghouse for best practices as well as a neutral evaluator of the accuracy and usefulness of various gen-A.I. tools.

What we know:

- The capabilities of gen-A.I. models are changing rapidly, with significant progress in capabilities and developments in industry standards every couple of months.
- Current gen-A.I. tools already offer functionality that can augment common tasks: written, visual, and audio content generation; software development; predictive modeling; and search.
- Gen-A.I. also presents security, privacy, communications, and coordination challenges to organizations, as well as risks related to bias and inaccuracy.
- Training data for gen-A.I. models is generally limited to publicly available information, which means it excludes the knowledge base curated by Analyst Institute. The black box nature of these models and tools also means that it is difficult to assess their quality and bias.

What we need to learn and build:

- Where large language model-generated content is created based on training sets that do not include community test results, we should provide guidance on how users can better compare suggested output with existing scripts, templates, and recommendations.
- Relatedly, we should explore secure tools that can integrate community research and recommendations to support high-quality, on-brand content generation.
- The ecosystem needs standards for both quality and transparency in tools that use artificial intelligence. These standards would give organizations the ability to judge the effectiveness and value of prospective tools, ensure the privacy of their data, and understand the biases inherent in any model.

Conclusion: Rebuilding with Purpose

The 2025–2026 Community-Informed Research Agenda is our call to refocus and reimagine how we build what comes next, together.

We don't have every answer. But we believe rigorous, transparent, and collaborative research, grounded in lived experience and built for the complexity of this moment, can help light the way forward.

Analyst Institute is proud to share this agenda with allies across the movement, and **we invite you to help shape what's next by asking bold questions, testing new ideas, and sharing what you learn.**

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Appendix: Research Priorities Summary

Conventional Tactics

Key Research Priorities

- Best practice canvassing for persuasion and mobilization
- Correspondence between survey and field-based ad RCTs
- Mail volume, timing, and content

Additional Research Priorities

- Sustained engagement and optimal outreach timing

Understudied or Emergent Tactics

Key Research Priorities

- Organic digital content and audience exploration
- Combining mobilization and persuasion

Additional Research Priorities

- Partisan voter registration
- Relational organizing beyond voter turnout

Foundational Research on Environmental Shifts

Key Research Priorities

- Messengers that resonate
- Understanding disengaged voters
- Power-building and the strengthening of democratic practice

Bridging Research and Practice

Key Research Priorities

- Last-mile problem
- Continued meta-analysis and learning from outliers
- Impact investment frameworks
- Incentivizing innovation and risk-tolerant research sharing
- Generative A.I.

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